

What Is Existence?

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The question: What is Existence? What exists? Does the thing that exists begin at some time?

This study examines these questions in **Madhyasth Darshan** (Co-existentialism), as presented by **Shri A. Nagraj**, and compares its answers with **Advaita Vedanta** and selected **modern philosophical and scientific approaches** to physical reality, consciousness, and selfhood.

Standpoint and scope

These studies are written from the standpoint of a **scientist and technologist** — someone trained to graduate-level **physics and mathematics**, at home with contemporary cosmology, quantum theory, conservation laws, and the logic of formal models.

From that background, a familiar picture of nature is hard to avoid: **consciousness appears as something the brain does** — an epiphenomenon, functional outcome, or emergent property of particular configurations of very large numbers of physical particles. Modern physics and cognitive science are powerful on mechanism, prediction, and public evidence; yet the hard problem of consciousness, the status of the self, and the reality of value remain fiercely contested. The standpoint taken here does not treat those gaps as settled in favour of matter-only reductionism.

The work begins where that scientific picture leaves open questions — and asks whether Madhyasth Darshan offers a coherent alternative worth examining seriously. This paper reads the primary texts carefully, states what follows from the darshan itself, and compares it in parallel with what we know from **physics and the natural sciences**, **Advaita Vedanta**, and **modern Western philosophy** (especially philosophy of mind). Physics and mathematics are **one leg** of that comparison, not the only one. The aim is rigorous comparative understanding — testing definitions, internal consistency, and fit with public knowledge — not persuasion or devotional endorsement.

These topical studies state the philosophy in clear, checkable prose first. A separate formal mathematical treatment may follow once the definitions and relations are stable across the studies; this paper does not assume or require that treatment.

How to read this study

Throughout, three things are kept separate:

- **[Text]** — what Shri Nagraj's literature states, quoted or paraphrased with citations.
- **[Interpretation]** — our compression, proposed reading, or comparative mapping of the texts.
- **[Open]** — unresolved tension, missing mechanism, or evidence not yet available.

Where a label is omitted on a quoted passage, the content is **[Text]**. Unmarked analytical paragraphs in §2–§4 are comparative exposition, not MD doctrine.

Quick Glossary

Term	Plain meaning
Existence (<i>astitva</i>)	In Madhyasth Darshan: beingness (<i>hona</i>) and indestructibility (<i>anashita</i>), always present as coexistence (<i>saha-astitva</i>).
Coexistence (<i>saha-astitva</i>)	Reality as Omnipresence (<i>satta</i>) and all units (<i>ikai</i>) inseparably present together.
Omnipresence / Space / Brahma / Satta	The all-pervasive, formless, non-transforming reality in which all units (<i>ikai</i>) are saturated (<i>samprikt</i> — submerged, soaked, surrounded: <i>dooba</i> , <i>bheega</i> , <i>gira</i>). The published translation also uses Omnipotence, Uniform/Equilibrium Energy, Space (<i>akasha</i>), Knowledge (<i>gyan</i>), Consciousness, God, and Absolute Energy for this same reality. This paper standardizes on “Omnipresence” as the primary English term and treats the other names as quotations from the source. “Consciousness” here is one name for this pervasive reality and must not be read as a knowing subject — sentience (<i>chaitanya</i>) proper belongs to the sentient unit (<i>jeevan</i>). See §1.6 for the tension this naming creates.
Unit (<i>ikai</i>)	A countable, bounded entity in nature, whether insentient (<i>jada</i>) or sentient (<i>chaitanya</i>).
Jeevan (Sentient Self)	The sentient self: a real, immortal, constitutionally complete unit (<i>gathanpurna parmanu</i>) that works through the body (<i>shareer</i>).
Constitutional Completeness (<i>gathanpurnata</i>)	The state achieved when an atom integrates the required number of particles to become indivisible, immortal, and sentient (a <i>jeevan</i>). Crucial to the emergence of sentience in §1.5.
Jada / *Chaitanya*	Insentient and sentient nature (<i>prakriti</i>).
The Four Orders (<i>chaar avastha</i>)	The real, stable developmental plateaus of nature in Madhyasth Darshan: Material (<i>padarth</i>), Pranic/Bio (<i>pran</i>), Animal (<i>jeev</i>), and Knowledge/Human (<i>gyan</i>).
Saturation (<i>samprikt</i>)	The source’s term for how units are held in Omnipresence. Treated in this paper as a metaphor requiring ontological specification (see §1.2).
Atman / *Brahman*	In Advaita Vedanta: the Self and the one ultimate reality, finally identical.
Paramartha / *Vyavahara*	In Advaita: Absolute reality (<i>paramartha</i>) where Brahman alone exists, versus empirical/transactional reality (<i>vyavahara</i>) where the world and individual selves operate.
Mithya	In Advaita: the world as dependent appearance, strictly <i>sad-asad-anirvacaniya</i> (indeterminable as either real or unreal).
Sat-Chit-Ananda	In Advaita: the threefold nature of Brahman / the true Self — being (<i>sat</i>), consciousness (<i>chit</i>), bliss (<i>ananda</i>).
Satkaryavada	The Vedantic doctrine that the effect pre-exists in its cause (the pot is already clay). Relevant to the causation discussion in §1.3.
Parinamavada / *Vivartavada*	Real transformation (<i>parinama</i> , seen in Sankhya and analogous to Madhyasth Darshan) versus apparent transformation (<i>vivarta</i> , the Advaita doctrine where effects are mere appearances on a changeless cause).
Physicalism	The modern view that every real concrete phenomenon is physical.
Panpsychism	The view that experientiality belongs, at least in primitive form, to fundamental physical reality.

Term	Plain meaning
Illusionism	The view that phenomenal consciousness, as usually conceived, is an illusion or misdescription.
Strong / weak emergence	Strong emergence: a higher-level property that is not deducible from, and adds something to, its lower-level base. Weak emergence: a higher-level pattern fully fixed by its base. Relevant to §1.5 and §3.3.

1. The Madhyasth Darshan Answer

The claim in one sentence: Existence (*astitva*) is the eternally present coexistence (*saha-astitva*) of formless Omnipresence (*satta*) and countless sentient (*chaitanya*) and insentient (*jada*) units (*ikai*) held within it; what exists never arises from non-existence (*abhava*) and is never annihilated, though units undergo motion, transformation, development, and awakening.

1.1 The Coexistential Structure: Space (*Satta*) and Nature (*Prakriti*)

Madhyasth Darshan does not define existence (*astitva*) as an object among objects, nor as a mental category imposed by a knower. It defines existence as the inseparable presentness of formless Omnipresence (*satta*) and formful nature (*prakriti*).

SB gives the most compressed formulation:

“What is evident is that consciousness and matter are inseparably present. Upon examining their fundamental nature, we learn that all of existence is essentially nature (matter) saturated in Omnipotence (consciousness). Here, ‘seeing’ is intended in the sense of understanding. Since nature saturated in Omnipotence is inseparably present, existence itself is eternally manifest in the form of coexistence.” - SB, p. 48

A note on the word “consciousness” in the translation. The published translation lists several names for the pervasive reality (*Satta / Vyapak*): Uniform Energy, Space (*akasha*), Knowledge (*gyan*), Consciousness, Omnipresence, Eternity, God, and Absolute Energy. The parenthetical “(consciousness)” therefore labels the all-pervasive reality, not a personal knowing mind. Sentience as the activity of a knower (*chaitanya*) is the status of *jeevan* (the sentient unit), not of Omnipresence (*satta*) itself. This distinction is essential, and it also generates a genuine tension in the source, addressed directly in §1.6.

The same passage rejects two familiar origin stories:

1. Matter (*jada*) does not arise from Omnipresence (*satta*).
2. Omnipresence (*satta*) does not arise from matter (*jada*).

The alternative is not creation of one from the other, but inseparable presentness, expressed in the language of “Realisation Knowledge” (*anubhav jnan*):

“Sentient and insentient nature saturated in Omnipotence. The countless sentient and insentient units are saturated in Omnipotence (Omnipresence).” - MVD, p. 11

“All units saturated in the Omnipresence (permeative and transparent) have form, properties, essential nature & dharma, and have inherent orderliness & participate in overall orderliness.” - MVD, p. 11

Existence thus has two inseparable aspects:

1. **Omnipresence (*Satta* / *Vyapak*):** The formless, all-pervasive, non-transforming, immeasurable reality. It is described as actionless energy (*kriya-shunya urja*): it performs no actions, yet its permeative presence is the ground in which nature is energized, regulated, and conserved.

“Omnipotence is not confined within any dimension of length or breadth, nor can any measure be established for it; therefore, Omnipotence is all-pervasive.” - SB, p. 49

“Knowledge itself is the omnipresent Omnipotence. This itself is referred to as Space.” - MVD, p. 35

2. **Units of Nature (*Ikai*):** The formful, active, countable, bounded entities. Units are not illusions in Omnipresence; they have determinate reality and remain surrounded, submerged, and soaked in it.

“Nature, saturated in Omnipotence, exists as countless units. Each unit, being saturated in Omnipotence, remains surrounded, submerged, and soaked in it.” - SB, p. 48

1.2 What Kind of Relation Is “Saturation”? (*Satta* and *Ikai*)

The source describes units as *samprikt* — soaked, submerged, surrounded — in Omnipresence. This is a vivid image, but an image is not yet an ontological relation, and the paper’s central claim (“coexistence”) stands or falls on what this relation actually is. Three candidate readings can be set aside, and a fourth proposed. [Interpretation] throughout this section unless a citation is given.

Not constitution. Omnipresence is not the stuff units are made of. Units have their own form, properties, and *dharma* (MVD, p. 11); Omnipresence is formless and non-transforming. If units were made of Omnipresence, their transformation would be transformation of it, which the texts deny.

Not inherence (*samavaya*). In the Nyaya-Vaisheshika sense, inherence binds a property to its substance. But Omnipresence is not a property the units possess, nor are units properties of Omnipresence. The relation is mutual and symmetric in a way inherence is not.

Not superimposition (*adhyasa*). This is the decisive contrast with Advaita. For Advaita, the world’s apparent location “in” Brahman is *adhyasa* — a false attribution later sublated. Madhyasth Darshan explicitly refuses this: units are real and perpetual, never sublated. So saturation cannot be *adhyasa*.

Proposed reading: pervasive co-location with energetic dependence. The most defensible reading is that Omnipresence is the omnipresent medium in which every unit is necessarily situated (co-location), and from which every unit draws the regulatory and conserving “energy ground” that keeps it in orderly existence (dependence), without Omnipresence acting, transforming, or being consumed. The relation is therefore one-directionally dependent (units depend on the medium; the medium does not depend on any unit) yet ontologically non-reductive (neither is the other).

The “actionless energy” paradox. This reading exposes a problem the source-language papers over: Omnipresence is called energy and credited with energizing, regulating, and conserving nature, yet is also called actionless (*kriya-shunya*) and non-transforming. Ordinarily, to energize or regulate is to act. The paper’s most charitable resolution is to read “energy” here not as a capacity to do work (the physics sense) but as an enabling condition — the way a field of space “permits” motion without itself moving, or the way the rules of a game constrain play without making any move. On this reading “actionless energy” means: the standing condition under which units are able to act, persist, and stay orderly. This is coherent, but it is a

substantive interpretive commitment, not something the texts state outright, and it should be flagged as such rather than smoothed over.

Consolidated definition of coexistence. On the reading above, coexistence (*saha-astitva*) is: the eternally present inseparability of formless Omnipresence (*satta*) and countless formful units (*ikāi*), where every unit is necessarily co-located in the medium, dependently sustained by it, and ontologically non-identical with it — neither made from it, nor projected onto it, nor finally cancelled by it.

1.3 Causation Within Coexistence

The origination question (“nothing comes from non-being”) is not the same as the causation question (“what does the causal work when units transform?”). The source is strong on the first and nearly silent on the second; this paper makes the gap explicit. *[Interpretation]* for the causal picture below.

If Omnipresence is timeless and actionless, it cannot be an efficient cause of change. Causal work must therefore be horizontal — unit acting on unit — while Omnipresence functions as the standing condition (in the sense of §1.2) that makes orderly interaction possible and conserves what exists. This yields a two-level causal picture:

1. **Conditioning level (Omnipresence):** non-acting, non-temporal, conserving. It does not push or pull; it grounds and sustains.
2. **Operative level (units):** acting, temporal, transforming. All efficient causation, development, and awakening happen here.

Comparison with *satkaryavada*. Advaita (following Sankhya’s vocabulary) holds *satkaryavada*: the effect pre-exists in the cause — the pot is already present in the clay. The clay-pot analogy you find in the *Vivekachudamani* (quoted in §2.3) is precisely a *satkaryavada* illustration deployed to show that effects are non-different from their material cause (and hence, for Advaita, ultimately Brahman). Madhyasth Darshan needs a different causal doctrine, because it denies a single material cause for everything. Its picture is closer to a transformation realism: real units with determinate natures interact and reconfigure, and “nothing is annihilated” guarantees that every transformation conserves an underlying reality (*vastu*) even as configurations (*roop*) change. This is a *parinamavada*-like (real-transformation) view at the level of units, combined with conservation — and it should be named as such to distinguish it cleanly from both Advaita’s *vivartavada* (apparent transformation) and Sankhya’s *satkaryavada*.

1.4 The Ontological Orders and Realist Relations of Nature

Nature (*prakṛiti*) does not exist as an amorphous mass, but as countless physical (*jada*) and sentient (*chaitanya*) units.

“Existence is not just physicochemical matter, but all physical, chemical and jeevan entities are inseparably present in Omnipresence.” - MVD, *The Alternative*, point 7

This is why the human being is understood as a joint form of a physical body (*shareer*) and a sentient self (*jeevan*):

“Brahma (Omnipotence) is omnipresent, and jeevan-clouds are many.” - MVD, p. 13

“The grandeur of humans as a joint form of jeevan and body.” - MVD, p. 13

Nature is organized into four real, objective **Ontological Orders** (*chaar avastha*), each defined by its innateness and purpose (*dharma*):

1. **Material Order (*Padarth Avastha*):** Bounded physical and chemical units (atoms, molecules, rocks). Its dharma is bare existence (*astitva / hona*).
2. **Pranic / Bio Order (*Pran Avastha*):** Organic cells, plants, vegetation. Its dharma is growth and biological propagation (*pushti / dharana*).
3. **Animal Order (*Jeev Avastha*):** Animals (body + *jeevan*). Its dharma is the expectation of alive-ness (*jeene ki aasha*).
4. **Knowledge / Human Order (*Gyan Avastha*):** Humans (body + *jeevan*). Its dharma is the expectation of continuous happiness and right-living (*sukh-dharmita*).

These are **objective categories in nature**, not human typologies: material atoms, living cells, animal organisms, and knowledge-order humans each occupy a real plateau whose *dharma* is fixed by the order itself.

[*Interpretation*] For readers approaching from neuroscience, Bhattacharya offers a compact secondary map of these orders: material and biological entities have no brain; some brain-endowed organisms (for example, insects) are said to function through nervous control **without** *jeevan*; animals with *jeevan* remain body-driven in the unawakened animal order; and in the knowledge order a fully developed brain becomes the instrument through which *jeevan* expresses thought and realization. Sentience is therefore not a property of the brain, but *jeevan*'s activity mediated through it — **Bhattacharya**, *The Relationship of Jeevan and Brain*.

Why the orders matter for the argument. These orders are not decoration: they are where “development without creation from nothing” (§1.5) becomes concrete. Each order is a real, stable plateau of organization that the next order presupposes and builds upon, so the upward movement from matter to human is development within coexistence, not the appearance of new substance. The same structure extends to **ecological complementarity** across orders — units in one order depend on and participate in the orderliness of others. The orders also carry the paper's ethical claim: because existence is coexistence, units exist in objective relations of complementarity (*poorakata*) and orderliness (*vyavastha*):

“Since existence is coexistence, complementarity and mutual recognition are eternally established.” - SB, p. 49

Relations (*sambandh*) and values (*mulya*) are therefore ontologically real, perpetual structural aspects of coexistence. In the human order, values like trust (*vishvas*), respect (*samman*), and gratitude (*kritagyata*) are the objective recognition and fulfilment of these existential relations. [*Interpretation*] Unlike physicalism (which tends to treat values as brain-model projections) or Advaita (which treats relations as provisional appearances), Madhyasth Darshan grounds ethical value in the actual structure of existence.

1.5 Development and Awakening — and the Emergence Problem

While Madhyasth Darshan rejects creation from nothing, it gives a developmental account of how an atom (*parmanu*) reaches sentient status. This is the transition to constitutional completeness (*gathanpurnata*), forming the immortal sentient self (*jeevan*):

“In the course of an atom's development, there comes a stage when the required number of particles for its constitution are all integrated, and at that point, it becomes constitutionally complete. Constitutional completeness signifies satisfaction within, by, and for that constitution. This is the immortality of the result, and the attainment of sentient status.” - SB, p. 59

“All types of atoms, including constitutionally complete ones, are eternally present through the natural law of coexistence in existence.” - SB, p. 59

The emergence tension (stated, not hidden). *[Open]* This is the most exposed point in the whole system, and honesty requires naming it. The account says a quantitative change — the right number of particles integrating — produces a qualitative change of kind: insentient becomes sentient. That is a strong-emergence claim. Yet in §3.3 the paper leans on Strawson’s argument that experience cannot emerge from the wholly non-experiential. Madhyasth Darshan therefore appears to use against reductive physicalism the very move it relies on for the origin of *jeevan*.

There are three possible replies, and the paper should commit to one rather than leave the tension dangling:

1. **Latency reply.** Sentience does not emerge from nothing; the potential for sentience is “eternally present through the natural law of coexistence” (SB, p. 59). Constitutional completeness is the actualization of a standing potential, not strong emergence. This is the most consistent reply, but it owes an account of where that potential “resides” before completeness — in the units, in Omnipresence, or in the law of coexistence itself?
2. **Threshold-as-form reply.** What changes at completeness is not the addition of a new ingredient but the achievement of a form (a stable self-maintaining constitution). Sentience is identified with that form’s “satisfaction within, by, and for that constitution.” This makes sentience a structural achievement, closer to weak emergence — but then it concedes ground to the self-model theorists of §4.1.
3. **Bite-the-bullet reply.** Accept that this is genuine strong emergence and that the Strawson borrowing in §3.3 must be qualified: Madhyasth Darshan agrees experience cannot emerge from the wholly non-experiential, and so must hold that the pre-complete atom is not wholly non-experiential — which pushes back toward the latency reply.

The honest conclusion is that the latency reply is the only one that keeps the system internally consistent with its use of Strawson, and that it is currently an assertion about latent potential rather than an explained mechanism. This is flagged again as an open problem in §6.2.

1.6 The “Knowledge but not Knower” Tension

The glossary insists that “Consciousness,” as a name for Omnipresence, must not be read as a knowing subject. Yet the source also says, flatly: “Knowledge itself is the omnipresent Omnipotence” (MVD, p. 35). So Omnipresence is called Knowledge (*gyan*) while being denied the activity of knowing. This is a real tension in the source, not merely a translation artifact, and the stronger scholarly move is to flag it rather than dissolve it in a glossary footnote.

[Interpretation] A charitable reading: *gyan* here names a condition of intelligibility — reality is such that it can be known, is orderly, transparent, lawful — rather than an act of cognition. On this reading Omnipresence is “Knowledge” the way a perfectly legible text is “meaning” even when no one is reading it. The knowing act (*chaitanya*) still belongs only to *jeevan*. This is coherent, but readers should be told it is an interpretation, and that a careless reading of MVD p. 35 collapses straight into Advaita’s *chit* (Brahman as awareness itself) — exactly the identification this paper otherwise resists.

1.7 The Mereology and Identity of *Jeevan*

[Open] Two questions the source leaves open, both logically prior to the *jeevan*–body interaction problem.

Is *jeevan* simple or composite? *[Interpretation]* *Jeevan* is called a “constitutionally complete atom” (*gathanpurna parmanu*), which suggests a structured composite (it is complete because the right number of particles integrated). Bhattacharya, synthesizing SB, lists five inseparable aspects — *mun*, *vritti*, *chitta*, *buddhi*, and *atma* — which supports this reading. But it is also called indivisible and immortal. A composite is, in principle, decomposable; so its claimed indestructibility needs a ground. The most consistent reading is that *jeevan*’s “indivisibility” is functional (the constitution is self-maintaining and does not spontaneously lose completeness) rather than mereological (having no parts). If so, “immortal” means “does not lose

constitutional completeness,” which is a weaker and more defensible claim than “has no parts and therefore cannot perish.”

What makes this *jeevan* the same *jeevan* over time? Advaita dissolves individuation (individuality is ignorance); physicalism grounds identity in bodily/psychological continuity. Madhyasth Darshan asserts that *jeevan* persists across bodily death and re-association but offers no explicit criterion of identity. An eternalist individual-self ontology needs one. The candidate implied by the texts is continuity of constitution — the same constitutionally complete configuration persists — but this needs to be stated and defended, because constitution-identity over a gap of embodiment (death to re-association) is exactly where the criterion is hardest.

1.8 Does Existence Begin? Time (*Kaal*) and Conservation

For Madhyasth Darshan, existence does not begin in the sense of coming from absolute non-existence (*abhava*). What exists has always existed, though its form, configuration, and states are in constant flux:

“That which exists continues to be, and that which was not, does not come into existence. Therefore, existence will remain as it is till eternity.” - SB, p. 49

“Nothing arrives at birth nor does anything depart with death. All that is, exists forever.” - JV, p. 20

Time (*kaal*) is not an independent cosmic dimension or background substance. It is the human measurement of the activity, change, and motion (*kriya / gati*) of units. Because formless Omnipresence is actionless and non-transforming, it is timeless; time applies only to the transformations of active units in nature.

This ontology distinguishes absolute annihilation (*vinasha*) from physical transformation (*roopantaran*). An entity changes configuration, but its underlying substance (*vastu*) is never destroyed:

“A piece of charcoal continues to exist in other forms even after burning it.” - JV, p. 20

“At the fundamental level, a ‘reality’ never gets annihilated.” - JV, p. 20

The result is a conservation-based ontology:

1. Existence (*astitva*) as coexistence (*saha-astitva*) is beginningless and endless.
2. Omnipresence (*satta*) does not begin, change, or end.
3. Units (*ikai*) do not arise from non-being (*abhava*) and do not vanish into it.
4. Particular bodies (*shareer*), configurations, relations, and states do begin and end.
5. Development (*vikas*) and awakening (*jagriti*) are real, but are not creation out of nothing.

Question	Madhyasth Darshan answer
Did existence begin?	No. Existence (<i>astitva</i>) is eternally present coexistence (<i>saha-astitva</i>).
Did units begin from non-existence?	No. “That which was not, does not come into existence” (<i>abhava</i>).
Do bodies begin and end?	Yes. Birth and death are events at the level of body (<i>shareer</i>) and association.
Does <i>jeevan</i> begin at birth?	No. <i>Jeevan</i> is immortal; birth and death are occurrences.

Question	Madhyasth Darshan answer
Does sentient status have a developmental account?	Yes. Constitutional completeness (<i>gathanpurnata</i>) is attainment of sentient status — within eternal coexistence, not as creation from nothing (see the emergence tension, §1.5).

1.9 The Perpetual World: *Brahma Satya Hai, Jagat Satat Hai*

MVD compresses the ontology into one line:

“Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.” - MVD, p. 13

This is a metaphysical commitment: Brahma (Omnipresence) and the world of units are both real, neither cancelled by the other. If the world is perpetual (*satat*), then matter (*jada*) is not ultimately negated, relationships (*sambandh*) are not merely provisional, and humane conduct (*manaviya aacharan*) is not merely preparatory to escape from the world.

Madhyasth Darshan thus rejects two reductions that would split this inseparable whole:

1. **Material reductionism:** only physicochemical matter (*jada*) exists.
2. **World-negating spiritualism:** only the formless ground (*satta*) is finally real, and the world is diminished to mere appearance.

Its positive claim: Brahma is real, the world is real, and their inseparable presentness is coexistence (*saha-astitva*).

2. The Advaita Vedanta Answer

The claim in one sentence: Existence in the strictest sense is Brahman alone, one without a second; the world of names, forms, bodies, and relations is *mithya*, a dependent appearance, and the true Self is neither born nor destroyed because it is identical with Brahman.

A note on fairness before proceeding: Advaita does not deny the empirical world; it subordinates it. The world is *mithya* — strictly indeterminable as real or unreal (*sad-asad-anirvacaniya*), not sheer nothing. The two-truths framework (*vyavahara / paramartha*) and the *mithya* doctrine are related but distinct tools, and this section keeps them apart.

2.1 Existence Alone, One Without a Second

“In the beginning this was Existence alone, One only, without a second.” - CU 6.2.1

Shankara glosses *sat* as:

“mere Existence, a thing that is subtle, without distinction, all pervasive, one, taintless, partless, consciousness” - CU 6.2.1, Shankara commentary

The text rejects existence arising from non-existence:

“By what logic can existence verily come out of non-existence? But surely, o good looking one, in the beginning all this was Existence, One only, without a second.” - CU 6.2.2

2.2 Sat-Chit-Ananda: Being, Consciousness, Bliss

A second classical formulation names existence not only as *sat* — bare being — but as **Sat-Chit-Ananda**: being-consciousness-bliss. These are not three realities added together; Brahman is one partless reality whose nature is expressed in three inseparable names.

“Brahman is Truth, Knowledge, and Infinity.” - TU 2.1.1

Shankara’s tradition reads *satyam* as being/reality, *jnanam* as consciousness, and *anantam* as the infinite. The *anandamaya* passage (TU 2.5) leads the seeker beyond even bliss-as-sheath to the Self beyond all coverings. Shankara states the mature formula in the *Vivekachudamani*:

“By that alone he comes to know his own Self as Existence-Knowledge-Bliss Absolute and becomes happy.” - VC, v. 152

The same triad recurs at v. 217. In this scheme:

1. **Sat** — Brahman is existence; to exist absolutely is to be Brahman.
2. **Chit** — consciousness is the very nature of reality and Self, not a function of brain or mind.
3. **Ananda** — bliss is the intrinsic fullness of the Self, free from lack and dependence on objects.

So for Advaita the answer to “what is existence?” is concentrated: existence is the one reality that is being, consciousness, and bliss without a second.

2.3 What Exists in Advaita?

Strict answer: Brahman alone exists absolutely. The world is not sheer nothing, nor absolutely real; it is *mithya*.

“A firm conviction of the mind to the effect that Brahman is real and the universe unreal, is designated as discrimination (Viveka) between the Real and the unreal.” - VC, v. 20

“The individual soul is itself and directly the Supreme Brahman, and nothing else.” - VC, v. 216

The clay-pot analogy (a *satkaryavada* illustration; see §1.3):

“All modifications of clay, such as the jar, which are always accepted by the mind as real, are (in reality) nothing but clay. Similarly, this entire universe which is produced from the real Brahman, is Brahman Itself and nothing but That.” - VC, v. 251

Level	What exists?	Status of world
Empirical (<i>vyavahara</i>)	Bodies, minds, causes, effects, duties, scriptures, practices	Operationally valid
Absolute (<i>paramartha</i>)	Brahman alone	World is <i>mithya</i> , dependent appearance

2.4 The Structural Entities of Advaita

Because Advaita utilizes a two-tier framework of reality, it posits several “entities” that are structurally necessary to explain the empirical world, even if they are ultimately sublated at the absolute level. These are the specific concepts compared against Madhyasth Darshan in §5:

1. **Brahman / Paramatman:** The sole absolute reality (*paramartha*). It is pure, actionless awareness.
2. **Maya / Avidya:** The ontological power of illusion (or individual ignorance). It is the mechanism that conceals Brahman’s true nature (*avarana*) and projects the multiplicity of the world (*vikshepa*).
3. **Ishvara (Saguna Brahman):** The personal Creator and governor of the universe. This is Brahman viewed through the lens of *Maya*, functioning as the operative and material cause of the empirical world.
4. **Jivatman (Jiva):** The individual embodied soul. It is the true Self (*Atman*) conditioned by physical and mental coverings (*upadhis*, such as the *Pancha Kosha* or Five Sheaths), trapped in the cycle of birth and death until realization.
5. **Jagat (Nama-Roopa):** The physical universe of names and forms. It is operationally valid during ignorance but ultimately a dependent appearance (*mithya*) resting on Brahman.

2.5 Does What Exists Begin?

Brahman does not begin: it is beginningless, partless, actionless, non-dual. The universe as name-form has origination at the empirical level, but its ultimate truth is Brahman. Creation is therefore not production from nothing; it is manifestation of names and forms on the basis of Brahman (*vivartavada* — apparent transformation, contrasted with the *parinamavada* of §1.3).

“The Supreme Brahman is, like the sky, pure, absolute, infinite, motionless and changeless, devoid of interior or exterior, the One Existence, without a second, and one’s own Self.” - VC, v. 393

3. Modern Philosophical Approaches

Having examined Advaita Vedanta’s world-subordinating non-dualism, we now turn to modern Western philosophy of mind. The contrast is stark: where Advaita asks how the empirical world arises from pure consciousness, modern philosophy asks how consciousness could possibly arise from a purely physical world.

The claim in one sentence: Modern philosophy of mind imposes a consistent pressure—a high burden of proof on any posit beyond the physical—and its debates on consciousness show that “what exists” remains fiercely contested.

3.1 Standard Physicalism: Concrete Reality Is Physical

“I take physicalism to be the view that every real, concrete phenomenon in the universe is...physical.” - *Strawson 2006, p. 2*

On this view, what exists are physical things, events, fields, organisms, brains, and processes. Minds and selves are functions, organizations, models, or processes of physical systems.

3.2 The Hard Problem: Experience Resists Reduction

“The really hard problem of consciousness is the problem of experience. When we think and perceive, there is a whirl of information-processing, but there is also a subjective aspect.” - *Chalmers 1995, p. 3*

“It is widely agreed that experience arises from a physical basis, but we have no good explanation of why and how it so arises.” - *Chalmers 1995, p. 3*

“the fact that an organism has conscious experience at all means, basically, that there is something it is like to be that organism.” - *Nagel 1974, p. 1*

For Madhyasth Darshan this is evidence that body-only ontology is incomplete. The physicalist reply — that an explanatory gap is not proof of *jeevan* — is the central disagreement, and the paper should grant that an explanatory gap is, indeed, not by itself an existence proof (see §6.2).

3.3 Panpsychist Physicalism: Experience as Fundamental

“Full recognition of the reality of experience, then, is the obligatory starting point for any remotely realistic version of physicalism.” - *Strawson 2006, p. 2*

“Experiential phenomena cannot be emergent from wholly non-experiential phenomena.” - *Strawson 2006, p. 12*

“Real physicalism, realistic physicalism, entails panpsychism.” - *Strawson 2006, p. 12*

This is closer to Madhyasth Darshan than reductive physicalism, since both refuse experience-from-dead-matter. But the agreement cuts both ways. Strawson’s anti-emergence principle is exactly what makes the *gathanpurnata* account of §1.5 hard: if experience cannot emerge from the wholly non-experiential, then either the pre-complete atom is not wholly non-experiential (latency reply, §1.5), or the threshold account is a form of the emergence Strawson rejects. Madhyasth Darshan also differs from Strawson in scope: it does not say every particle is a subject; sentience is the status of constitutionally complete atoms only. The two views share an enemy (dead-matter reductionism) but not a metaphysic.

3.4 Illusionism: Phenomenal Consciousness as Misdescription

“Another approach, which holds that phenomenal consciousness is an illusion and aims to explain why it seems to exist.” - *Frankish 2016, p. 1*

“illusionists deny the existence of phenomenal consciousness properly so-called, but do not deny the existence of a form of consciousness” - *Frankish 2016, p. 8*

Madhyasth Darshan regards this as another reductionism: it treats experience, valuation, aspiration, and realization as activities of *jeevan*, not brain-model illusions. Illusionism matters because it shows how far naturalism will go to preserve a physicalist ontology.

3.5 Alternative Ontologies: Process & Neutral Monism

The philosophy-of-mind sources are not the closest Western kin to Madhyasth Darshan; two others are, and this section now engages them directly.

Whitehead's process philosophy is arguably the closest analogue: plurality is real, relations are ontologically fundamental, and reality is perpetual becoming rather than static substance. His basic units are "actual entities" — "drops of experience, complex and interdependent" (Whitehead 1929, p. 28) — which resemble units-in-relation, and his refusal to bifurcate nature parallels the refusal of both world-negation and matter-only reductionism. The key contrast: Whitehead's occasions are momentary and "perpetually perish" subjectively, gaining "objective immortality" only as data for successors (Whitehead 1929, p. 44), whereas Madhyasth Darshan's *jeevan* is a persisting immortal individual — so the two agree on relational realism but disagree sharply on individual persistence.

"Actual entities 'perpetually perish' subjectively, but are immortal objectively." -
Whitehead 1929, p. 44

Neutral monism (Russell, Mach) resembles the account of Omnipresence as a reality that is neither mind nor matter but the common ground of both. Russell holds that mind and matter are "composed of a neutral-stuff which, in isolation, is neither mental nor material" (Russell 1921, Lecture I). Mach likewise denies any "rift between the psychical and the physical": "There is but one kind of elements, out of which this supposed inside and outside are formed" (Mach 1914, Ch. XIV). The contrast: neutral monism typically builds mind and matter out of the neutral stuff, whereas Madhyasth Darshan keeps Omnipresence non-transforming and lets units be real in their own right rather than constructed from the ground.

"Both mind and matter are composed of a neutral-stuff which, in isolation, is neither mental nor material." - *Russell 1921, Lecture I*

"There is no rift between the psychical and the physical, no inside and outside... There is but one kind of elements, out of which this supposed inside and outside are formed."
- *Mach 1914, Ch. XIV*

3.6 The Structural Entities of Modern Philosophy

To prepare for the comparative matrix in §5.2, the structural entities assumed across these modern philosophical approaches can be summarized as follows:

1. **Cosmic Ground (Neutral Stuff / Creativity):** For neutral monism, the ground is an underlying "neutral stuff" that is neither inherently mental nor material. For process philosophy, it is the dynamic, forward-moving process of creativity itself, rather than a static substance.
2. **Individual Self (Self-Model / Experiential Monads):** In physicalist models, the self is not a distinct entity but an evolved cognitive architecture (a self-model). In panpsychism, the fundamental units of reality are "experiential monads" or "drops of experience" that compose higher-level minds through complex organization.
3. **Material Reality (Physical Matter):** In standard physicalism, concrete reality is entirely physical matter and energy. In panpsychism, physical matter is often viewed as the "outer" observable aspect of

units whose “inner” nature is experiential.

4. **Causation (Efficient / Creative):** Standard physicalism relies strictly on efficient, mechanistic causation. Process philosophy introduces “creative causation” or “conrescence,” where past entities are gathered into a novel present experience.

4. Modern Scientific Approaches

The claim in one sentence: Modern science, across cognitive science and cosmology, seeks to explain the self as an emergent natural process and the universe as a physical evolution, occasionally finding resonance with conservation principles but resisting claims of eternal sentience.

4.1 Cognitive Science & Neuroscience: The Brain as Generator of Self

Self-model theories in cognitive science (pioneered philosophically by Metzinger 2003) build upon the physicalist premise. They argue that the self is not an immortal unit, but a predictive model generated by the brain to regulate the organism:

“minimal selfhood emerges as the result” - Limanowski and Blankenburg 2013, p. 1

“these accounts propose to ‘understand the elusive sense of minimal self in terms of having internal models that successfully predict or match the sensory consequences of our own movement, our intentions in action, and our sensory input’.” - Limanowski and Blankenburg 2013, p. 3

This is nearly the opposite of the *jeevan* ontology. For Madhyasth Darshan the self is a real sentient unit using the body; for self-model theory the self is a model generated by embodied prediction. Note, though, the awkward proximity flagged in §1.5: the “threshold-as-form” reading of constitutional completeness moves Madhyasth Darshan uncomfortably close to “self as self-maintaining structure.”

4.2 Physical Cosmology: Does the Physical Universe Begin?

The standard cosmological model suggests the observable universe — including space and time — had a beginning at a singularity ~13.8 billion years ago. Taken as the absolute origin of all physical reality, this would challenge a beginningless ontology. However, because General Relativity breaks down at the Planck scale, several non-singular models have been proposed:

1. **Loop Quantum Cosmology (Big Bounce):** quantum-gravity effects replace the singularity with a “bounce” from a prior contracting universe. Ashtekar and Singh summarize the program:

“For matter satisfying the usual energy conditions any time a curvature invariant grows to the Planck scale, quantum geometry effects dilute it, thereby resolving singularities of general relativity.” - Ashtekar and Singh 2011, abstract

In the homogeneous isotropic models they review, the classical big-bang is replaced by a quantum bounce: the matter-density observable that diverges at the singularity is bounded by quantum dynamics (Ashtekar and Singh 2011, §III).

2. **Conformal Cyclic Cosmology (Penrose 2010):** an infinite sequence of aeons, each aeon’s far future becoming the next’s hot dense start.

3. **Eternal Inflation / Multiverse (Guth 2007):** our bubble began, but the eternally inflating background does not.

Use with caution. These are competing speculative programs, not consensus. Even loop quantum cosmology remains a research program, not settled science. The most this paper should claim is a conceptual resonance: several serious research programs are comfortable with a beginningless physical substrate even when local configurations begin and end — which is consonant with the claim that nature (*prakriti*) is perpetual (*satat*). It does not establish it.

4.3 Physics & Conservation Laws

The “nothing is annihilated” principle and modern physics — handle with care. Particle–antiparticle annihilation and pair creation are not passages into or out of absolute non-being; in quantum field theory (see standard treatments, e.g., Weinberg 1995), particles are localized excitations of conserved, all-pervasive fields, and annihilation transforms one excitation (matter) into another (radiation) under strict conservation laws. This is broadly consonant with the claim that fundamental reality (*vastu*) is conserved while configurations (*roop*) transform. But the alignment should not be overstated: fields are not “substances that persist” in quite the sense *vastu* intends, and energy conservation itself is subtle in General Relativity (it is tied, via Noether’s theorem, to time-symmetry that need not hold globally in an expanding spacetime; see Carroll 2010). The right verb is “is consonant with,” not “is supported by.”

Fields vs. vastu. In quantum field theory, what persists are field configurations and conserved quantities; a “particle” is a localized excitation, not a tiny enduring substance. Madhyasth Darshan’s *vastu* names an underlying reality that survives every *roop*-change. The parallel is structural (configuration changes, something is conserved), not identity of category: fields are mathematical-physical entities governed by equations, not countable units with *dharma* saturated in Omnipresence.

Time (kaal) vs. spacetime. Modern physics treats spacetime as a dynamical entity — it can expand, curve, and in some models begin locally. Madhyasth Darshan treats time as the measurement of unit activity, not an independent cosmic container; Omnipresence is timeless. The contrast is over whether temporality belongs to the ground of reality or only to transforming units.

Entropy vs. orderliness (vyavastha). Thermodynamics describes a statistical arrow toward disorder in closed systems. Madhyasth Darshan asserts inherent orderliness at every order, with development toward greater organization when units are in their natural state. These are not straightforward opposites — biological and ecological systems can increase local order at the cost of entropy elsewhere — but they use different notions of “order,” and the paper should not treat the second law as evidence for or against coexistence. [Interpretation] for the three contrasts in this subsection.

4.4 Summary: Does What Exists Begin, in Modern Thought?

1. **Physicalism & cosmology:** organisms, stars, and local universes begin and end; the deeper substrate may or may not be beginningless — unsettled.
2. **Self-model theories:** the self begins developmentally; no eternal individual self.
3. **Panpsychism:** experientiality may be fundamental; particular minds still depend on organization.
4. **Illusionism:** phenomenal consciousness “never begins” only because, in the realist sense, it does not exist; what begins are quasi-phenomenal states.

Against all of these, Madhyasth Darshan makes a stronger claim: coexistence is eternal, units are not annihilated, and *jeevan* is immortal. This eternalism is consistent with conservation principles and beginningless cosmological models, but its claims about individual immortality and constitutional completeness remain distinct metaphysical assertions not validated by current science.

4.5 The Structural Entities of Modern Science

To align with the comparative matrix in §5.2, the fundamental categories assumed by modern scientific approaches (cognitive science, physics, cosmology) are:

1. **Cosmic Ground (Spacetime & Quantum Fields):** The ultimate physical substrate is dynamic, expanding spacetime and fluctuating quantum fields. This ground has no inherent consciousness, purpose, or teleology.
2. **Individual Self (Cognitive Agent / Organism):** The self is understood strictly as a biological and brain-generated process. Mind is what the brain *does*. There is no immortal essence, and individual consciousness ceases entirely upon brain death.
3. **Material Reality (Matter & Energy):** Matter and energy are localized excitations of the underlying quantum fields. They are governed strictly by the laws of thermodynamics, gravity, and quantum mechanics, and are perpetually conserved.
4. **Causation & Order (Physical Causation & Ecology):** All causation is physical, underpinned by mathematical laws and entropy. Relationships in the biological domain (ecology, cooperation) are understood as evolved strategies that maximize survival and minimize free energy (homeostasis).

5. Comparison

This section is purely descriptive; evaluation is reserved for §6.

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern physicalist approaches
What is existence?	Eternally present coexistence: Omnipresence plus all units held in it.	Brahman / Existence alone, one without a second.	Concrete physical reality, studied empirically.
What exists absolutely?	Omnipresence and real units, sentient and insentient.	Brahman alone.	Usually the physical; experience disputed.
Is the world real?	Yes. "Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual."	Empirically valid but ultimately <i>mithya</i> .	Yes, as physical reality.
Does existence begin?	No. What exists does not come from non-existence.	Brahman does not begin.	Particular systems begin and end; cosmology unsettled.
Does the individual self begin?	<i>Jeevan</i> does not begin at birth or die with the body.	<i>Jiva</i> is ultimately Brahman; individuality is ignorance.	Self develops as biological/cognitive process.
What changes?	Forms, bodies, configurations, awakening.	Names and forms appear and are sublated; Brahman is changeless.	Physical and mental configurations change.
Causal doctrine	Real transformation of units + conservation (<i>parinama</i> -like).	Apparent transformation (<i>vivartavada</i>).	Physical causation; mechanism.
Method of knowing	Study, realization, behavior, experiment.	Scripture, reasoning, contemplative discrimination.	Observation, modelling, public evidence.

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern physicalist approaches
Ethical consequence	Humane conduct evidences understanding of coexistence.	Ethics prepares the mind for liberation.	Ethics via naturalism, social/normative theory.

5.1 The Sat-Chit-Ananda contrast, distributed

Advaita's Sat-Chit-Ananda and Madhyasth Darshan's coexistence can sound alike — both speak of being, consciousness, and fulfilment. The contrast is over what those words name and whether the world survives them.

For Advaita, *sat*, *chit*, *ananda* are three names for one ultimate reality without a second; the world is finally *mithya*. For Madhyasth Darshan, the same vocabulary is distributed across coexistence, not compressed into one subject:

Concept	Advaita Vedanta (Unified Non-Dualism)	Madhyasth Darshan (Distributed Coexistence)
Sat (Being)	Brahman alone is Sat; the world is a dependent appearance ultimately negated.	Beingness (<i>astitva</i>) is coexistence of formless Omnipresence and countless real units.
Chit (Consciousness)	Pure awareness, identical to the inner Self; the world of names/forms is inert.	Omnipresence is pervasive knowledge/condition-of-intelligibility (§1.6), but active sentence (<i>chaitanya</i>) belongs to the <i>jeevan</i> unit.
Ananda (Bliss)	Intrinsic nature of Brahman; sensory joy is a distorted reflection.	Harmony realized within the awakened <i>jeevan</i> , expressed as humane conduct.

Modern philosophy has no parallel formula: it may treat experience as physical, fundamental, or illusory, but it does not name existence as Sat-Chit-Ananda or as coexistence.

5.2 Comparative Matrix of Entities

The table below provides a systematic comparison of how primary entities, their functions, and their usefulness are conceived across different approaches. The **Other Religions** column is illustrative only — a full treatment of Abrahamic, Buddhist, and other Eastern ontologies is outside this paper's scope.

Entity Category / Attribute	Madhyasth Darshan (Co-existentialism)	Advaita Vedanta (Non-Dualism)	Other Religions (Abrahamic & Other Eastern)	Contemporary Philosophy (Process, Physicalist, Panpsychist)	Modern Science (Physics, CogSci, Cosmology)
Cosmic Ground	Omnipresence (Satta / Space): Pervasive, formless, actionless energy (<i>kriya-shunya</i>). Saturated units draw energy/order from it.	Brahman: The single, non-dual absolute reality (<i>Sat-Chit-Ananda</i>). The world is <i>mithya</i> (dependent appearance).	Creator God (Abrahamic, e.g., Genesis 1:1): Personal, active creator <i>ex nihilo</i> . Ishvara (Dvaita): Supreme lord. Shunyata (Buddhism; see Nagarjuna): Emptiness.	Creativity / God (Process): Dynamic process. Neutral Stuff (Neutral Monism): Common element.	Spacetime & Quantum Fields: Dynamic, physical substrate. No inherent consciousness or teleology.
Individual Self / Sentience	Jeevan: A constitutionally complete, immortal atom (<i>gathanpurna parmanu</i>). Many distinct, eternal <i>jeevan</i> exist.	Jivatman / Atman: Individuality (<i>jivatman</i>) is an empirical illusion caused by conditioning (<i>upadhi</i>). The true Self (<i>Atman</i>) is identical to the Supreme (<i>Paramatman</i>).	Soul / Jivatma: Created by God (Abrahamic); eternal dependent atomic units (Dvaita). Anatta (Buddhism): No permanent self.	Self-Model (Physicalist): Evolved cognitive model. Experiential Monads (Panpsychism): Fundamental experience.	Cognitive Agent / Organism: Brain-generated process. Mind is what the brain <i>does</i> . No survival post-death.
Material Reality / Body	Jada Units / Shareer: Real, perpetual, transforming matter. Composes the body, which acts as the vehicle for <i>jeevan</i> .	Nama-Roopa / Mithya: Form and name; operationally valid in <i>vyavahara</i> but ultimately negated in <i>paramartha</i> .	Creation: Physically real, created by God for human stewardship (Abrahamic). Real modification of Prakriti (Dvaita/Samkhya; see Ishvarakrishna).	Physical Matter: The primary concrete reality (Physicalism); or the outer aspect of experiential units (Panpsychism).	Matter & Energy: Consolidated excitations of quantum fields. Governed by conservation laws. Perpetual in base fields.

Entity Category / Attribute	Madhyasth Darshan (Co-existentialism)	Advaita Vedanta (Non-Dualism)	Other Religions (Abrahamic & Other Eastern)	Contemporary Philosophy (Process, Physicalist, Panpsychist)	Modern Science (Physics, CogSci, Cosmology)
Relationships & Moral Order	Coexistence / Complementarity: Inherent, ontologically real values (<i>mulya</i>) and orderliness (<i>vyavastha</i>).	Preparatory Ethics: Valid at the empirical level (<i>vyavahara</i>) to purify the mind, but sublated at the absolute level.	Divine Command / Karma: Ordaigned by God's will (Abrahamic); or the natural law of cosmic moral retribution (Karma).	Social / Internal Relations: Relationality constitutes the self (Process); or evolutionary strategies for survival (Physicalism).	Ecology & Cooperation: Interdependent biological networks. Cooperation is an evolved behavioral strategy.
Primary Causation	Transformation Realism (Parinama-like): Units interact and reconfigure; <i>Satta</i> is the conserving energy ground.	Vivartavada: Apparent transformation. The effect is an appearance on the changeless Brahman (clay/pot).	Divine Will / Satkaryavada: God's efficient cause (Abrahamic); or pre-existent effects in Prakriti (Samkhya).	Efficient / Creative Causation: Physical mechanisms (Physicalism); or "conrescence" of prehensions (Process).	Physical Causation: Underpinned by mathematical laws, conservation of energy-momentum, and thermodynamic entropy.
Ultimate Purpose / Realization	Awakening (Jagriti): Realization of coexistence, leading to resolved humane conduct (<i>manaviya aacharan</i>) in society.	Liberation (Moksha): Dissolution of ignorance (<i>avidya</i>); realizing identity with Brahman (<i>Aham Brahmasmi</i>).	Salvation / Devotion: Union with God in heaven (Abrahamic); eternal loving service to Ishvara (Dvaita); Nirvana (Buddhism).	Flourishing / Adaptation: Cognitive adaptability (Physicalism); or enriching the aesthetic intensity of experience (Process).	Survival & Adaptation: Natural selection, entropy minimization (Free Energy Principle, Friston 2010), and systemic homeostasis.

5.3 Is It Possible to Map Madhyasth Darshan to Advaita?

[Interpretation] throughout this section and §5.4. While the two systems arise from different core commitments (Advaita: non-dualism; Madhyasth Darshan: co-existentialism), several key entities in Advaita find close analogues or functional equivalents in Madhyasth Darshan:

1. Brahman corresponds to *Satta* (Omnipresence / Space)

- **Mapping:** Both are formless, all-pervasive, non-transforming, timeless, and actionless. Both serve as the ontological ground of everything.
- **Divergence:** Advaita's Brahman is the *sole* absolute reality (*paramartha*), making the world an appearance (*mithya*). Madhyasth Darshan's *Satta* coexists with nature (*prakriti*); both are real. Brahman is awareness itself (*chit*), whereas *Satta* is actionless energy (*kriya-shunya urja*)—the

condition of intelligibility—while active sentence (*chaitanya*) belongs exclusively to the *jeevan* unit (§1.6).

2. Paramatman / Atman corresponds to Atma (in Jeevan) / Jeevan

- **Mapping:** Both point to the true, immortal, non-material reality of the self. Within the five-fold structure of *jeevan*, the *Atma* represents the innermost core of realization.
- **Divergence:** Advaita holds that the true Self (*Atman*) is exactly identical to the single, universal Supreme Self (*Paramatman*). Madhyasth Darshan denies a single universal self; it holds that *jeevan* units are permanently distinct, multiple, and active.

3. Jivatman (Jiva) corresponds to Deluded Jeevan (Bhramit Jeevan)

- **Mapping:** Both represent the individual embodied self experiencing the world, bound by ignorance (body-identification), and seeking liberation or resolution.
- **Divergence:** In Advaita, the distinction between *Paramatman* and *Jivatman* is maintained only at the empirical level (*vyavahara*) due to conditioning (*upadhis*); upon liberation, the *jivatman* dissolves into *Paramatman*. For Madhyasth Darshan, individuality is ontologically real and eternal; realization (*jagriti*) resolves delusion but preserves the active, distinct individuality of the *jeevan*.

4. Jagat / Nama-Roopa corresponds to Nature / Units (Prakriti / Ikai)

- **Mapping:** Both point to the physical universe of change, bodies, name, and form.
- **Divergence:** In Advaita, the Jagat is ultimately *mithya* (dependent appearance) and sublated at the highest realization. In Madhyasth Darshan, the world of units is *satat* (perpetual) and eternally real.

5. Pancha Kosha (Five Sheaths) corresponds to Five Functional Layers

- **Mapping:** Both map human structure through five layers: *annamaya* (food/body), *pranamaya* (vitality), *manomaya* (mind), *vijnanamaya* (wisdom/intellect), and *anandamaya* (bliss/realization).
- **Divergence:** In Advaita, these sheaths are coverings that conceal the Self and must be negated (*neti-neti*). In Madhyasth Darshan, they are the **real functional equipment** of the human being (comprising body and *jeevan*) that are affirmed and harmonized in awakened living.

5.4 Unmappable Entities

Certain central entities and categories in Advaita Vedanta cannot be mapped to Madhyasth Darshan because they represent concepts that co-existentialism explicitly rejects:

1. Maya (as an Ontological Power of Projection/Concealment)

- Advaita's *Maya* is the cosmic power that conceals Brahman (*avarana*) and projects the illusion of the world (*vikshepa*). Madhyasth Darshan has no equivalent cosmic power or substance of illusion. Ignorance (*agnyan* / *bhrama*) is not a force or substance but merely the temporary cognitive absence of understanding (lack of awakening), which is resolved through study and education.

2. Adhyasa (Superimposition)

- In Advaita, the world is superimposed (*adhyasa*) on Brahman like a snake on a rope. Madhyasth Darshan has no concept of ontological superimposition. The relationship between units and *Satta* is **saturation (samprikt)**—a real, mutual, non-reductive co-location and energetic dependence, not a projection or false attribution.

3. Mithya (Ontological Status of Dependent Appearance)

- Advaita introduces *mithya* (strictly *sad-asad-anirvacaniya* — neither absolutely real nor sheer nothing) to describe the world. Madhyasth Darshan rejects any intermediate ontological status:

everything that exists is real, perpetual, and indestructible.

4. Ishvara (Personal Creator / Governor with Will)

- In Advaita, *Saguna Brahman* or Ishvara is the personal God who governs the world. Madhyasth Darshan rejects a personal creator deity who plans, acts, or dispenses grace. Orderliness (*vyavastha*) is self-regulation (*swatah-sasput*) inherent in the natural laws of the co-existing orders, and *Satta* is entirely actionless (*kriya-shunya*).

5. Kaivalya / Dissolution (as Ultimate Liberation)

- Advaita seeks the dissolution of individuality into Brahman (*jiva-brahma-aikya*). Madhyasth Darshan rejects dissolution; the ultimate goal is **awakened coexistence (*jagriti*)**, where individual *jeevan* units remain distinct and active, living in harmonious relationships (*sambandh*) with other humans and the ecological orders.

Conclusion on Mapping: The attempt to map Madhyasth Darshan to Advaita Vedanta reveals fundamental difficulties. While surface-level analogues exist, the core ontological commitments are ultimately irreconcilable. Advaita is a world-subordinating non-dualism that views individuality and the universe as dependent appearances (*mithya*) to be transcended. In stark contrast, Madhyasth Darshan is a relational realism that affirms the eternal distinctness of sentient units and the perpetual reality of the world. Because of these profound differences, a true one-to-one mapping is impossible without distorting the foundational claims of either system.

5.5 Where the alliances fall

No single tradition wins every dispute. Three pairwise patterns clarify what each view shares with and denies to the others:

Madhyasth Darshan and Advaita against physicalism. Both refuse to treat existence as merely physicochemical matter. Consciousness, value, and the self are not exhaustively explained as brain-generated epiphenomena. Against reductive materialism, both hold that something more than bare mechanism is required — though they disagree sharply on what that “more” is.

Madhyasth Darshan and science against Advaita. Both treat the world as real and worth studying. Matter, bodies, relationships, and ecological order are not finally *mithya* or preparatory illusion. Against world-negating non-dualism, both insist that nature and society have final weight — though science does not affirm Omnipresence or immortal *jeevan*.

Advaita and science against Madhyasth Darshan. Both set a high bar for claims that exceed public evidence. Advaita dissolves individual *jeevan* into Brahman; science treats the self as a biological process that ceases at brain death. Against Madhyasth Darshan’s eternal distinct sentient units, both deny — on different grounds — that an immortal individual self is established.

Each pair agrees on something the third denies. Comparative clarity depends on naming which question is at stake: matter-only reduction, world-reality, or individual immortality.

6. Critical Review

6.1 Internal coherence of the Madhyasth Darshan position

Judged on its own definitions — not as proof against rivals — the ontology hangs together in several ways:

1. **It answers the three questions directly.** Existence is beingness and indestructibility as coexistence; what exists is Omnipresence and all units; what exists does not begin from non-being.
2. **It avoids world-negation.** “Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual” preserves the reality of nature, society, relationship, and ethical responsibility.

3. **It avoids simple material reductionism.** It refuses to treat consciousness, value, and selfhood as mere byproducts of body-chemistry.
4. **It links ontology and conduct.** If existence is coexistence, human fulfilment must be evidenced as coexistence in behavior, not merely believed.
5. **It is conservation-based.** “Nothing existent is annihilated” gives internal coherence to its account of body, *jeevan*, death, transformation, and development.

These are strengths **within** the system’s premises. They do not by themselves establish those premises against Advaita or physicalism (see §6.2–6.4).

6.2 Open problems for Madhyasth Darshan

The items below are not footnotes; they mark what any later rigorous treatment of this ontology must settle — whether in philosophy, experiment, or both. Several turn on relations and entities this paper has defined in prose but not fully explained.

1. **The emergence of sentience is unexplained, not merely unmeasured.** The strongest internal tension (§1.5): constitutional completeness must be the actualization of a latent potential rather than strong emergence, or it contradicts the anti-emergence principle borrowed from Strawson. The latency reply keeps the system consistent but currently asserts, rather than explains, where the potential resides before completeness.
2. **The Satta–Ikai relation is a metaphor awaiting an ontology.** “Saturation” needs to be specified (§1.2); “actionless energy that energizes” must be read as enabling condition, not efficient cause, and this reading is interpretive.
3. **The “Knowledge but not knower” tension (§1.6) must be managed,** or Omnipresence collapses into Advaita’s *chit*.
4. **The mereology and identity of *jeevan* (§1.7) need defense:** functional vs. mereological indivisibility, and a criterion of identity across the death-to-re-association gap.
5. **From indestructibility to *jeevan* is not publicly established.** That reality is not annihilated does not by itself prove a distinct sentient unit survives bodily death.
6. **Constitutional completeness is not yet operational.** It is central but not presently measurable in physics or chemistry.
7. **The *jeevan*–body interaction needs articulation.** If *jeevan* drives the body, how does intention become neural and muscular activity?
8. **The evidence standard differs from science.** Realization and behavior are cited; science accepts public behavioral evidence but not private realization as establishing ontology without independent testability. The epistemic standards of realization, study, and conduct as proof are examined separately in the study on knowledge, knower, and known.

6.3 Strengths and Limits of Advaita

Advaita has a powerful answer to non-being (existence cannot arise from non-existence) and a rigorous first-person method of discriminating seer from seen. Its limit, from the Madhyasth perspective, is that making the world *mithya* makes it harder to ground the ultimate reality of relationships, nature, society, and conduct. Advaita’s fair reply: ethics and compassion remain valid at the empirical (*vyavahara*) level, and realization of non-duality deepens rather than weakens them. The Madhyasth counter-reply: an ontology that makes the world *mithya* cannot give the world the same final weight coexistence gives it. This is a genuine disagreement about final ontological status, not a defeat of Advaita on its own terms — and the paper should present it that way.

6.4 Strengths and Limits of Modern Approaches

Modern approaches are strongest where Madhyasth Darshan is weakest: public evidence, empirical correction, cognitive modelling, precise mechanism. Self-model theory explains many features of embodied selfhood without an eternal *jeevan*; illusionism shows how a naturalist can reinterpret even the apparent obviousness of experience. But modern philosophy is not unified: Chalmers and Nagel show experience resists reduction; Strawson shows some physicalists move toward panpsychism. So it is inaccurate to say “modern philosophy has proved the self is only the brain.” It has not — but it has set a high evidential bar for any claim of an immortal sentient unit.

6.5 Can These Systems Be Adjudicated at All?

A methodological caveat the paper owes its reader. The three systems do not merely give different answers; they partly use different criteria for what counts as existing — public testability (physicalism), scriptural plus contemplative discrimination (Advaita), and realization-plus-behavior-plus-experiment (Madhyasth Darshan). To that extent they are partially incommensurable, and no single neutral tribunal settles them. What can be done, and what this paper attempts, is narrower: test each for internal consistency, for fit with what is publicly known, and for whether its distinctive posits are responsibly distinguished from bare assertion. On that triad, Madhyasth Darshan’s most exposed point is the emergence of sentience (§1.5); Advaita’s is the final status of the world; physicalism’s is the hard problem.

7. Conclusion

Madhyasth Darshan’s answer to the paper’s three questions is exact:

1. **What is Existence?** Eternally present coexistence: formless Omnipresence and formful units inseparably present.
2. **What exists?** Omnipresence exists; countless sentient and insentient units exist; their form, properties, nature, dharma, mutuality, and orderliness exist.
3. **Does what exists begin?** No. What exists does not come from non-existence and is not annihilated. Bodies and configurations begin and end; existence and existent realities persist through transformation.

Its most distinctive formulation —

“Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.” - MVD, p. 13

— marks the difference from Advaita and physicalism at once: against Advaita, the world is not *mithya*; against physicalism, existence is not merely physicochemical matter; against both, reality is neither world-negation nor matter-only, but coexistence.

The philosophical strength of this view is that it makes the world, relationships, conduct, and ecological responsibility fully real. Its unresolved challenges are two, and they are different in kind. The evidential challenge — clarifying how *jeevan*, constitutional completeness, and post-death continuity can be studied or responsibly distinguished from metaphysical assertion — remains open. The internal-coherence challenge — reconciling the developmental origin of sentience with the anti-emergence principle the system relies on, and specifying the Satta-Ikai relation beyond metaphor — is equally open. The most promising route on the latter is the “latent potential within the law of coexistence” reading, made explicit and defended rather than assumed.

In Madhyasth Darshan itself, careful study of existence is only the starting point. Understanding is fulfilled when coexistence becomes clear in one’s own seeing and evident in conduct — in recognition of relationships, fulfilment of values, resolution in thought, responsible work and experiment, and the ability to convey the

understanding to others. The open problems listed in §6.2 are therefore not reasons to dismiss the comparative project; they mark where study, responsible experiment, and later rigorous work must continue.

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